

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ K Q J 3

♥ K 10 4

♦ J 9 3

♣ 7 4 3

♠ 9 8 4

♥ A 6 2

♦ A Q

♣ A J 9 8 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 6 2

♥ Q J 8 3

♦ 10 7 6 2

♣ K 6

♠ A 7 5

♥ 9 7 5

♦ K 8 5 4

♣ Q 10 2

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

2NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

With 9 points and a balanced hand you go into Invitational Mode. Bid 2NT. Partner will raise to 3NT with a maximum, pass with a minimum. Today he has a middling 16 points, but bids 3NT anyway.

The contract would be 3NT played by South.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥3 and West plays the ♥K.

Do you hold up or not?

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 6

You count 3 ♦ tricks but will need to be careful to get all 3. And obviously your three extra winners will have to be from the ♣ suit.

Most important for now, how do you read the ♥ suit? Do you hold up?

East has 4 ♥s because he led the ♥3 and you can see the ♥2. Therefore you should NOT hold up because they can only win 3 ♥s and the ♣K right now. But if you hold up, West might pocket his ♥ trick and switch to ♠s, where you are just as bad off.

So win the ♥A and unblock the ♦ A Q. then play ♣J, expecting to lose the trick. In fact, East takes his ♣K.

East cashes his 3 ♥ tricks, then plays a ♠. Pounce with dummy's ♠A, cash the ♦K, then take your 4 ♣ tricks and the game.

It was tempting to get over to dummy to try the ♣ finesse. But it was a temptation which had to be ignored. After all, how would you get to dummy? By wasting a ♦ winner? Or by using your only ♠ stopper?

Not all finesses should be taken - certainly not this one.

Another possibility, playing ♣A first, should also be rejected. On the rare day where the ♣K fell singleton you might be happy, but on the more frequent days where a defender held ♣ K x x and took the third ♣ trick you'd feel like a complete fool. Rightly so.

Board 3

North Deals

E-W Vul

♠ K 6
 ♥ J 6 4
 ♦ K 9 7 5 4
 ♣ J 7 3

♠ Q J 10 9 3

♥ K 9 7

♦ A 3

♣ Q 10 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A 7
 ♥ A 8 3 2
 ♦ Q 6 2
 ♣ A K 6 2

♠ 8 5 4 2

♥ Q 10 5

♦ J 10 8

♣ 9 8 5

West	North	East	South
	1 ♠	1NT	Pass
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			
3NT by East			

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 5

When the going gets tough, the tough better figure out a good plan! Although you MIGHT manage to get an extra trick in ♥s or ♣s, you can see that your only real chance is to find a distribution that will give you 4 ♦ tricks. With that in mind, where do you win the first trick?

Without thinking it through you might decide to save that entry to dummy and win the first trick in your hand. But to get the 4 ♦ tricks you need you are going to have to make them play their ♦A WITHOUT using one of your two honors. That means the ♦A must be doubleton, AND you must lead through it. And NORTH is the one most likely to hold ♦A x.

You win dummy's ♠K and play a low ♦. When North follows with the ♦3 you play your ♦Q which wins.

Then play a low ♦ from your hand, and **DUCK IN DUMMY**. North plays the ♦A on this trick and you are now home-free!

When you bid boldly you will get into a lot of contracts that are . . . challenging.

Sometimes you must try to visualize some possible distribution of the defender's cards which will allow you to make your bid and then just go ahead and play for that distribution.

A takeout double would not be a terrible bid. But if you don't overcall 1NT right now it will be hard to later convince partner that you have 17 points balanced. So you bite the bullet and say 1NT. Partner now bids 2NT.

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There is no point bidding ♥s; you are absolutely sure that partner does not have four of them. He has told you to bid 3NT with a maximum so you bid 3NT.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♠8. Of course South leads his partner's suit.

Board 5

North Deals

None Vul

♠ J 8
♥ 5 3 2
♦ J 9 8 5
♣ K Q 10 7

♠ 9 5

♥ K Q 7

♦ K Q 7 3

♣ A J 9 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ Q 10 6 4

♥ A 4

♦ A 10 2

♣ 8 4 3 2

♠ A K 7 3 2

♥ J 10 9 8 6

♦ 6 4

♣ 5

*West**North**East**South*

1NT

Pass

2♥

Pass

2♠

Pass

3♥

Pass

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by South